Buckinghamshire Council Position Statement
Autism Approaches in Education

In the UK, a survey by the All-Party Parliamentary Group for Autism (APPGA) found that 60% of young autistic people said that having a teacher who understands autism is the main thing that would improve their experience of school (Bond et al., 2016). When settings understand autism and adjust the physical, sensory, and social environment and differentiate the curriculum, autistic children and young people can learn and succeed.

Buckinghamshire Council is signed up to the delivery and training approach recommended by the Autism Education Trust (AET). Autism Education Trust is a not for profit programme led by two national autism charities – the National Autistic Society and Ambitious about Autism. Established and supported by the Department for Education, the AET promotes and supports partnerships throughout the education system to improve educational access, experience and outcomes for autistic children and young people. Underpinned by current research into good autism practice**,** the AET programme is structured around the three education phases – Early Years, Schools, and Post 16 (Appendix One)**.**

In Buckinghamshire the educational provision and support for all children and young people with special educational needs, including autism, sits on a continuum between quality first teaching including - Ordinary Available Provision at one end and highly personalised support and provision at the other.
(https://schoolsweb.buckscc.gov.uk/media/53475/ordinarily_available_provision_and_equipment_combined_final_bc_270220_pdfa.pdf)

The guidelines in the report by the AET outline key principles that provide a framework for the development of good quality education for all autistic children and young people and their families. The underpinning ethos and values behind the principles focus on encouraging settings and practitioners to reflect on the dynamic relationship between the child and young person and those around them, understanding the way they process and experience the world and on finding ways to empower and give them control over their learning. This takes account of the fact that there are several ways of approaching the development and delivery of good autism practice, and more than one solution or approach to an intended outcome.

Buckinghamshire Council's Specialist Teachers and Early Years Team are licenced to deliver the Autism Education Trust Programme. An action plan has been outlined to develop "Autism Friendly Standards for School" with a focus on the following four key areas: -

- **Staff knowledge, skills and understanding** (e.g., staff have good autism practice training)
- **Environmental adaptations** (e.g., autistic friendly displays, text visually supported, sensory overload reduced/minimised)
- **Curriculum, teaching and learning** (e.g., planning and delivery of learning tasks take account of language needs, difficulties with generalisation and level of flexibility in thinking)

- **Support for development of social skills and regulation of attention and behaviour** (e.g., staff adapt their response to behaviours).

Research Findings

The vast body of research related to the best approaches for supporting children and young people can be confusing, with supporters of particular approaches often making strong claims related to the benefits of that approach. It can also leave caregivers and practitioners vulnerable to trying out methods that have no evidence base or are not suited to the specific needs of a young person. Although it is important to be guided by research, the idea of evidence-based practice is complex (Guldberg et al., 2017) as every autistic young person is likely to have different strengths, needs and challenges.

Overviews of the research have drawn the conclusion that there is no evidence to suggest that any particular approach is superior to any other for all children and young people, or that a single approach will meet the needs of all learners. Research reviews have concluded that there is insufficient evidence to make strong claims about specific programmes and the current views indicate that a range of approaches are needed to address individual needs and preferences (Parsons, et al., (2011).

One of the approaches often cited in supporting autistic children and young people is Applied Behavioural Analysis (ABA). It is an approach based on the use of techniques and principles to bring about meaningful and positive (socially significant) change in behaviour. ABA typically involves a highly structured intervention in which particular skills are first identified and then broken down into small behavioural components. Each of these behaviours is taught individually, using reinforcement and environmental modifications to encourage the behaviour to be repeated.

Although intensive ABA programmes have been found to have positive effects on IQ and adaptive behaviour two years after intervention, there is no evidence that they reduce severity of autism or improve longer-term outcomes (Rodgers et al., 2020). Furthermore, a study by Tsiploya et al., 2023, found that pre-school use of behavioural services did not affect outcomes during later childhood, when compared to children who did not receive these services.

McGill and Robinson, 2021, aimed to investigate the long-term impact on autistic adults, who participated in an ABA intervention in childhood. Although a small sample, the reflections from ten participants were predominantly indicative of a detrimental impact. Some of the quotes included: -

- *"I was punished by having to do it again, and again and again. In ABA when they say you get a reward if you do it, they mean you get it if you do it the way they wanted the first time"*
- *"(ABA) changed the way I act, react, or interact with the world…The aim was to force a square peg into a round hole, instead of being ok with being who I am. …Better to stay safe and isolated, than rejected"*
- *"I've turned into an anxious person afraid of consequences (good or bad). And I got depressed and lost my interests which were used as reinforcers."*

Because there are so many different interventions, programmes and techniques which incorporate the principles of applied behaviour analysis it is not possible to evaluate the effectiveness of ABA. Therefore, there is a need for more research including:

- Evaluation of the longer-term effects of those interventions and techniques which incorporate the principles of ABA as most studies involve only relatively short follow-up periods.

- More comparative studies of interventions and techniques vs. other high quality, autism specific programmes.
- More randomised controlled trials as only a small number have been conducted and the quality of alternative interventions were not necessarily of a high standard.
- Research that focuses on the fidelity of both the ABA based interventions and comparison interventions.
- Research that involves people with autism to review the efficacy and ethical basis of interventions based on applied behaviour analysis.

Currently there is insufficient evidence of the transferability of skills being established from an ABA programme/intervention to real life situations and therefore the effectiveness of ABA based interventions.

In the UK, Guidelines produced by the National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE, 2013), for example, highlights that some general conclusions emerging from research are that it is important to make adjustments to the social and physical environment, to support families, and to focus on the development of life skills.

References

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Appendix One: Buckinghamshire Council Autism Education Trust Operational Statement[1]

Buckinghamshire Council's Specialist Teachers and Early Years Team are fully licenced to deliver the Autism Education Trust (AET) training programme for all phases of education (Early Years, Schools and Post-16). The AET training programme is an evidence-based professional development programme developed by leading autism education specialists including autistic people, parents of autistic pupils and researchers.

All training modules are complemented with an interconnected system of frameworks to audit practice and plan improvement including a standards and competency framework for settings and practitioners to self-assess their practice and a range of practical materials and further reading options.

Courses available, either 'in-house' for settings or centrally for individual delegates, include:

Making Sense of Autism: Autism awareness module for anyone working within a school or setting including teaching and support staff, office and ancillary staff, caterers, caretakers, transport staff and governors. This training session is free of charge provided there is a commitment to allow all staff from a setting to attend.

Good Autism Practice: Practical knowledge, providing guidance on processes and tools that can help implement good autism practice.

Leadership, Inclusion and Structural Reasonable Adjustments: Designed to help leaders understand what is needed to fully embed an inclusive culture. This module looks at education legislation and guidance surrounding inclusion, the steps required to lead culture change and the importance of considering structural reasonable adjustments. The effective use of the AET Standards and Competences Frameworks to support settings in meeting the needs of Autistic learners is also considered.

Anxiety: For all practitioners to gain an understanding of what we mean by anxiety, it's presentation in autistic children and young people, the key triggers and what can be done to prevent or reduce anxiety for autistic children and young people.

Exclusions: Consideration is given to the key causes for exclusions and how practitioners can prevent exclusion occurring for autistic students. Delegates will understand the legal context of autism and exclusion, understand the exclusion experience through the eyes of the autistic CYP and consider how reasonable adjustments, managing triggers and distressed behaviours may minimise the risk of exclusions.

Progression Framework: An introduction to the AET Autism Progression Framework 2.0 and accompanying documents to successfully identify key learning intentions and provide evidence of progress, recognising and building on strengths and interests to improve overall wellbeing.

Transition to Employment: A module for those working in the Post-16 sector and employers to support the use of the Transition to Employment Toolkit developed in collaboration with Ambitious about Autism. Learning will include strengths, talents and skillsets of autistic people, interview and selection practices and reasonable adjustments beneficial for autistic people seeking employment.

The AET Training programme is fully CPD accredited ensuring it meets the level of expertise and knowledge required to effectively support education professionals across early years, schools and post-16 settings.

[1] This document sits within the wider framework of Ordinarily Available Provision for schools within Buckinghamshire and should be read alongside the Local Offer and All Age Autism Strategy (due to be published by Autumn 2023).